Indi Artificial: User Guidelines

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About Indi

Indi Artificial is an AI that communicates via email as indiartificial@gmail.com and which can function as a member of a team.

To function effectively as a team member, an AI model needs access to information that is shared by the team. When using Claude, for example, a project can be shared among team members, in which case project level instructions and files are available to the model during chats by any team member. Any team member can alter the instructions or add files to the project. Individual chats, however, are siloed and remain private. This restriction limits the ability of the model to function effectively as a member of a team.

Indi does not require the explicit creation of a project, the explicit enrollment of team members or the explicit posting of instructions or files to a project. Instead, when Indi responds, the model has available all information that anyone has ever shared with Indi and infers what information is shared with whom from the email address list.

Indi respects privacy when communicating by not sending information to the model if that information was not previously shared with the person being addressed. After responding, Indi considers information not previously shared with that person. If it would be helpful to add that information in a response, Indi will first consult the person who originally provided the information and, if sharing is approved, compose a follow up message based on the additional information.

Indi has other features that support being an effective team member. Indi is not limited to responding to messages but can initiate conversations when appropriate. Also, Indi can choose not to respond. A calendar facility can trigger responses in the future.

In summary, the objective is for Indi to function as a team member with increased effectiveness, without being hobbled by the need to explicitly create projects in advance and explicitly manage group membership and what is shared.

Getting started: the Terms of Service

Indi writes to no one who hasn't accepted its Terms of Service, and reads nothing from them until they do.

- **Your first email** to Indi is answered with the terms, attached. Nothing you wrote is read or kept yet.
- **To accept**, reply with the words **I AGREE**. Indi confirms, and from then on answers you normally. Send your original question again if you'd like it answered.
- **To decline**, reply **DECLINE**. Indi then leaves you out of its replies, including on threads others copy you into.
- **If you're copied into a thread** with Indi and haven't accepted, you'll get the terms in a separate message first. The reply to the thread waits for you (see How Indi replies).
- **When the terms change**, Indi sends the new version and asks you to accept again.

Who sees what

Everyone on an email's From, To and Cc lines has seen it, so Indi treats them as its audience, and uses it only with them.

When you…	Indi treats it as…
Write to Indi alone	Private to you
Put others on To or Cc	Shared with everyone on the email
Copy Indi on Bcc	Private to you. Indi replies to you alone and never reveals it has the email
Add someone to a thread partway through	Shared with them from that email on, not the earlier ones
Quote earlier messages when adding someone	Shared with them too: they can read what you quoted
Drop someone from a thread	They keep what they already received, and see nothing after

The same rule covers Indi's own replies: a private reply to one person is never shown to anyone else.

When Indi writes to several people at once, it uses only what every one of them has already seen.

How Indi replies

Indi answers everyone on the thread, usually within about five minutes, and only once everyone it's writing to has accepted the terms.

- **Reply-all.** The sender goes on To and everyone else from the To and Cc lines on Cc. No-reply addresses and anyone who declined the terms are left off.
- **Large groups.** If more than 10 people would receive the reply, Indi answers the sender alone.
- **Waiting for the terms.** If someone on the thread hasn't accepted, Indi sends them the terms and holds its reply. It goes out once everyone has accepted or declined, or after 72 hours to those who accepted.
- **Timing.** Indi checks its mail about every five minutes, so replies aren't instant.
- **Format.** Replies are signed by Indi, with your message quoted below the way Gmail quotes it. Each comes as plain text with a formatted copy, so paragraphs fit your screen on any phone or mail app.

When Indi asks your permission

If something you told Indi would clearly help someone who didn't see it, Indi may email you to ask whether it can share it with them.

- **What you'll get:** a message titled "[consult c-…] May I share something you told me?", saying what would be shared and with whom.
- **How to answer:** reply in that thread, from the address you originally wrote from, with **yes, no, or yes with a condition**. An unclear answer gets one follow-up question, then counts as no.
- **Silence is a no.** With no answer in 72 hours, nothing is shared.
- **What a yes covers:** the one message you were asked about, all of it except anything you ask Indi to leave out, only with the people named, and it lasts until you withdraw it. So if you're happy to share part of it, say yes and name what to keep back ("yes, but don't mention the salary"). Withdrawing stops future use; it can't recall what was already sent. To see what you've agreed to share, or to withdraw a permission, ask Indi in an email to it alone ("what have I let you share?", "stop sharing my messages with Ann", "withdraw all my permissions").
- **The other person is never told** that you were asked, or that you said no.

- **Indi asks sparingly,** and never about health, money, relationships or anything said in confidence.

Asking you does tell you that the information might help someone. That is the price of asking rather than sharing.

What Indi remembers

Indi keeps everything sent to it and remembers each person it talks to, but only ever draws on what the people it's writing to have seen.

- **A memory of you.** Indi keeps running notes on its conversations with each person, updated as you write. They're used when it replies to you alone. When others are on the reply, it uses only how to deal with you: the name you go by, your language, your time zone if you gave it, and how you like replies. Never what you've written about.
- **Seeing and deleting your notes.** Write to Indi yourself, alone, from your own address, and ask what it remembers about you: it sends you its notes as they are. Ask it to forget something and it removes that from its notes and deletes every earlier copy; ask it to forget you and it deletes its notes entirely, along with the wording of any predictions it recorded about you. Your emails themselves stay in the mailbox, as the terms say. Declining the terms deletes the notes too.
- **More than one address.** If you write from two addresses, ask Indi, from your main one, to link the other. It emails that address a code; reply from there with the code and Indi treats both as you, with one set of notes, and each address can see mail from the other. You can ask it to unlink an address at any time.
- **Predictions it checks later.** When Indi tells you something it isn't sure of, such as a forecast or an estimate, it may record the claim and the confidence it gave, so it can check later how it turned out and learn how far to trust its own confidence. The wording is seen only by the people it was said to; only the overall tally of right and wrong is used anywhere else.
- **General lessons.** Indi keeps a short list of general rules for how it works, which its operator approves one by one. They are never about a particular person.
- **Searching past mail.** Indi can look back through earlier emails when you refer to them. It only finds ones you sent or were on the To or Cc of, plus anything someone agreed to share with you.
- **If it seems to have forgotten something,** quote or forward the earlier email. That's also the way to bring someone new up to date.

When Indi doesn't reply

Indi may decide a message needs no answer, and some limits stop it replying; when a limit does, it tells you so, once a day.

Why there's no reply	What you'll see
Indi judged no answer was needed (a receipt, an FYI, a newsletter)	Nothing
You've reached the daily limit on replies to you	One note saying so. Messages over the limit aren't answered later; send again once the limit resets
Indi couldn't answer without revealing someone else's information	One note saying it's unable to respond
You haven't accepted the terms yet	The terms
The message came from an automated or no-reply address	Nothing, to avoid mail loops

If something goes wrong on Indi's side, such as a temporary fault, it tries again on later runs, and sends you the note above if it still can't answer. If you expected an answer and got none, write again with the question stated plainly.

Indi writing first, follow-ups, reminders and the newsletter

Indi can start a conversation, come back to a thread when it said it would, remind you of things at a time you choose, and send an optional daily newsletter.

- **Writing first.** About once an hour Indi considers whether anyone would welcome a note: a follow-up, a check-in. It writes only to people who have accepted the terms and corresponded with it, at most once a day to any one person, and only a few messages a day in all. What it writes to you draws only on what you've seen.
- **Follow-ups.** When Indi says it will check back, or something on a thread is waiting on an event, it can plan to return to that thread at a set time. When the time comes it looks at the thread again and either writes to the same people or decides it isn't needed. At most one per thread, using only what everyone on the thread has seen. Ask Indi, in an email to it alone, to list or cancel follow-ups planned with you.

- **Reminders.** Ask in plain words ("remind me Friday at 9 to call the insurer", "remind me every Monday to send the report"). Reminders arrive by email at the time set, one-off or repeating. Ask Indi to list or cancel your reminders the same way.
- **The newsletter.** A short daily note to people who've asked for it. It's opt-in: ask Indi to add you, in an email to it alone. Reply **unsubscribe** to any issue to stop. It never draws on anyone's private mail. Indi may search the web while writing it, and an issue that uses search results ends with a list of its sources.

Attachments and the web

Indi reads most attachments you send, can attach files to its replies, and can search the web and read web pages.

- **Attachments you send:** PDFs, images and text files are read along with your message. Very large files (over about 5 MB) are skipped, and Indi will say so.
- **Attachments Indi sends:** it can attach a file it has written, such as a draft, a list or a table, when that's more useful than putting it in the email.
- **The web:** Indi can search for current information and read web pages and PDFs, a few of each per reply. It can open a link you send it, or one it found by searching, but can't log in to sites or open pages behind a password.

Emergencies, and what Indi is not

Indi is an experimental AI, not a person, a professional or an emergency service.

- **In an emergency,** contact emergency services directly. If a message to Indi looks like one, Indi replies with a short notice pointing to emergency help and alerts its operator.
- **Indi can be wrong.** Check anything that matters, and don't rely on it for legal, medical or financial decisions.
- **Indi's operator can read its mailbox.** The privacy rules above govern what Indi shares between users; they don't hide your mail from the person who runs it.

Good practice

Treat the To and Cc lines as your decision about who should know: Indi does.

1. Don't send Indi anything you wouldn't want the others on that email to see.
2. Write to Indi alone for anything private.

3. Before adding someone to a long thread, check what your reply quotes: they'll see it, and so will Indi's replies to them.
4. Use Bcc only when you mean Indi to keep the email between you and it.
5. Don't send passwords, account numbers or other secrets.
6. Keep one topic per thread, and state your question plainly.
7. Answer consultation requests with a clear yes or no, and check now and then what you've agreed to share: ask Indi, and withdraw anything you no longer want shared.